the lights to be on permanent green. That put an end to the revving for a while, though not for long enough.

It was around this time I began to think about my biological father. I had no view of him when I was a child. I had a view of my stepfather as a good father and was loyal to him in that way. I called him Dad. My actual father wasn't mentioned much, neither pejoratively or otherwise, and I suppose that was just tactful of my mother, given Brett's commitment to us. There had been no visitation and that was standard in Australia at the time; the idea was that you didn't contaminate the dynamics of the new family with regular and possibly resentful incursions from the old. My childhood was pretty much without stress and I didn't think about him all that often.

But something happens to boys in puberty. You have this sudden spike in self-awareness and hopefully in intelligence. You're suddenly embracing the world and rejecting parts of it, too. In quick time I was a father myself, and I had taught myself with books. The books had become special to me, all that Dostoevsky, Koestler, Kafka, and I think I realised at the time that I wasn't getting that interest from a mysterious source. It took me years to discover that it was probably coming from my father. During those years, it seemed an unnecessary emotional complication, the idea of seeking out my father, but, nonetheless, I felt his presence in me. By the time I was completing university, I saw that a significant part of who I was, whoever I was, had come from this invisible person who might have helped me.

After a little correspondence, we spoke on the phone. And then I went up to Sydney to see him. It was odd. They came to the airport to meet me – my father, his partner and a son. I had brought my bike with me, which my father decided to ride back to their house in New Town, while we went ahead in the car. The partner was curious: a film producer, clearly besotted with him but in some way unconventional. My father had, at some point around thirty-five, decided to retrain as an actor. I don't know if the experience was an opening-up of things, or a closing-down, but it was poignant all the same to be in the house and see him. And I had a weird experience there. In the evening I walked around the house looking at his bookshelves. I found myself getting sort of angry as I did so, because there, on shelf after shelf, were the exact same books as those I had bought and read myself. I suddenly realised I had started from the bottom of myself, on the first rung, and built myself up via many trials and tribulations, when, all